

Chapter 1

Daksha Prajapati and His Lineage

A tale from the primeval age of creation, where the seed of the story of the Great Sati is sown

Work: Mahasati Gauri (The tale of Mother Gauri and Mother Parvati - from Mother Gauri's own perspective) · Series: Shri Adishakti Mahakosh · Author: Adishakti Bhagavati Maa Ambe (Servant - Suraj Kumar Lohani)

By Mother's grace, a mere servant (nimitta) - it is Mother's own work - it is Mother's own glory.

Invocation (Mangalacharan)

या देवी सर्वभूतेषु शक्तिरूपेण संस्थिता।

नमस्तस्यै नमस्तस्यै नमस्तस्यै नमो नमः॥

Meaning - To that Goddess who abides in all beings in the form of power (shakti), I bow again and again — this is the all-pervading form of Adishakti, Bhagavati Mother Ambe, who shall remain invisibly present on every page of this tale.

The Early Dawn of Creation

Creation was still newborn. The reckoning of time had not yet become as refined as it would be in the ages to come, yet one thing was certain: Brahma's cosmic play of creation was still in its earliest stages. The Prajapatis born of his mind had only just taken up their respective domains — some became sages, some the lords of the directions, some the regulators of time, some helpers in the work of creation. This was the age when the very laws of creation were still being forged, when every Prajapati was shaping the world according to his own nature.

Among these mind-born sons was Daksha — radiant, industrious, fond of rules, and exceedingly skilled in organization. His body glowed with an inner brilliance, his speech carried the tone of command, and his gaze always held some plan, some purpose. While other Prajapatis remained absorbed in tapasya (penance) and contemplation, spending hours in meditation, Daksha's nature was altogether different. He believed that to keep creation stable, action was needed, yajna (sacrificial rite) was needed, the expansion of lineage was needed, and above all, the strict observance of rules was needed. In his eyes, dharma meant the observance of rule, the purity of yajna, and the propriety of lineage. Whatever lay beyond this simply did not exist for him.

Asikni and the Family of Sixty Daughters

Daksha was married to Panchajani Asikni, who was herself the daughter of Virani Prajapati. Asikni was simple, affectionate, and exceedingly patient — she balanced Daksha's stern, rule-bound nature with her own tenderness. Where Daksha gave commands, Asikni explained. Where Daksha imposed rules, Asikni softened them with love. The couple complemented one another — one the emblem of sternness, the other the very image of maternal tenderness.

In time, many daughters were born to them — sixty daughters, as the Puranas describe. This was no ordinary family, but a lineage whose daughters would go on to set in motion the wheel of time, the wheel of the seasons, and the very cycles of nature throughout creation. Of these, ten were married to Dharma Prajapati, thirteen to the sage Kashyapa — from whom arose the Adityas, the Daityas, the Danavas, the Nagas, and many other races — twenty-seven were married to the Moon, from whom the constellations were born. The remaining daughters were married to other sages and Prajapatis. This expansion of Daksha's lineage was wondrous — as though the entire diversity of creation were blossoming forth from a single family.

A Hint of One Special Daughter

Among these sixty daughters was one whose destiny differed from all the rest. Her birth was not for any worldly purpose, but to unveil one of the most profound mysteries of creation. She was neither to become the bride of any Prajapati, nor to be bound by any ordinary rule. Asikni had a sense — through some subtle intuition — that this child would be different from all the others, though she could not put it into words.

Daksha's Pride and His Power

Daksha's prestige grew day by day. He came to be regarded as foremost among the Prajapatis — his yajnas were magnificent, and his assembly was attended by all the gods, sages, and gandharvas. He received the title "Daksha Prajapati" — meaning the skilled, able, capable Prajapati. Brahma himself praised his organizational ability. Indra, Agni, Varuna, Kubera — all the guardians of the directions attended his yajnas with reverence. His assembly was no less magnificent than the assembly of heaven itself.

But alongside power and prestige, a subtle pride also began to take root within him. He came to believe that the entire order of creation ran by his own rules, that yajna and ritual observance (karmakand) alone were the ultimate truth. This pride was so subtle that Daksha himself could not recognize it — he took it for his own "righteous, dharma-abiding nature," not for pride. This is the most dreadful thing of all — when pride dons the garb of dharma.

Daksha's View of Lord Shiva

Daksha had heard many times about Lord Shiva — that he dwelt on Kailash, smeared himself with ash, wandered in cremation grounds, kept company with ghosts, spirits, and his ganas, performed no yajna, and observed no rituals. In Daksha's eyes, all this was a mark of incivility. He could not understand that the ash adorning Shiva's body was the supreme truth of creation's transience; that the cremation ground where Shiva wandered was precisely the place where attachment and pride were shattered most completely. For Daksha, outward appearance was everything — the tapasya within, the vairagya (detachment) within, the compassion within, were entirely hidden from his sight.

The Limits of Outward Vision

Daksha was great, was capable, but his vision was confined only to the visible world — yajna, rule, society, propriety, outward appearance. He could not see that unseen, formless truth which existed in the form of Shiva. This very limitation would, in time, forge a conflict between him and his own daughter — one that would be etched forever into the history of creation.

A Prophecy in Brahma's Assembly

Once, all the Prajapatis gathered in Brahma's assembly. The subject was the plan for the coming expansion of creation, and how dharma was to be established in the ages ahead. The assembly was magnificent — sages, Prajapatis, gods, all were present. In that very assembly was also present the sage Narada, who forever wandered the three worlds knowing the deep secrets of past and future, and whose voice, drawn from his veena, could render even truth melodious.

Daksha proudly recounted his countless daughters and their marriage alliances. He described how, through his daughters, the constellations, the Daityas, the Nagas, the Gandharvas — the entire diversity of creation — had come into being. He was praised in the assembly. Daksha's heart swelled with pride. Just then Narada smiled and said, "O Prajapati, among your daughters there will also be one who will become the bride of no Prajapati, who will be bound by no ordinary rule. She will be the very descent of Adishakti, and she will be wed to that Lord Shiva whom you now hold in contempt."

The Dialogue Between Daksha and Narada

Daksha (with astonishment and mild contempt) - Narada, what are you saying? That one of my daughters should choose that naked ascetic, that dweller of cremation grounds, that lord of ghosts and spirits — this is impossible. For all my daughters I have chosen only worthy, socially respectable husbands. Such dishonor shall never befall my lineage.

Narada (in a grave voice) - Prajapati, the one you call "the lord of ghosts and spirits" is himself the death of death. The day your daughter is born as Sati, you yourself will understand that the greatest law of creation — love and devotion — is greater than any human-made propriety. He whom you hold in contempt today will tomorrow be chosen by your most beloved child — and you will not be able to stop it.

Daksha (laughing, though with a vague unease within) - Time alone will tell, great sage. But I shall never allow the propriety of my lineage to be broken under any circumstance. My daughters shall be married by my decision alone, not by infatuation with some ascetic.

Narada (rising, taking his leave) - Remember this, Prajapati — the rules that man makes, the universe itself sometimes overturns. Your own daughter shall become the witness to this truth.

Narada's words pierced Daksha's mind like a thorn. Though outwardly he brushed it off with laughter, attempting to conceal his discomfort before the other Prajapatis present in the assembly, deep within an unknown foreboding took root in his heart. When he returned to his palace that night, Asikni saw lines of worry upon his face. When she asked, Daksha deflected the matter — "It is nothing, only the usual talk of the assembly." But Asikni, with a woman's natural intuition, understood that something unusual had occurred.

Asikni's Inner Anguish and a Divine Resolve

Meanwhile, upon the utterly remote, silent peaks of Kailash, where no yajna was ever performed, no ritual observed, where only snow, silence, and meditation held sway, Lord Shiva sat absorbed in his own meditation. His eyes were half-closed, the stream of the Ganga subtly present within his matted locks, the blue stain of poison upon his throat — and upon his face was a peace that lay beyond the clamor of all three worlds.

From the very beginning of creation, his Shakti — called at times Yogamaya, at times Prakriti, at times Adishakti — had remained present with him in one form or another. Shiva and Shakti were never two, always two lights of the one same essence. But now the time had come for that Shakti to descend in the form of a human, visible, affectionate daughter, so that into Shiva's ascetic, solitary life the spirit of householdership and worldly love might enter — and so that creation might also receive the message that even the Supreme Shiva is incomplete without Shakti, that tapasya and householder life are not mutually opposed but mutually complementary.

The Mystery of Ardhanarishwar

Shiva and Shakti were never separate — they were forever contained within one another in the form of Ardhanarishwar. The birth of Sati was no new event, but a visible, narrative manifestation of that same undivided Shakti, which the world, with its limited understanding, binds into words like "marriage" and "wife" — whereas in reality this was the divine play of the Self reuniting with the Self, a drama in which both the actor and the witness were Adishakti alone.

Adishakti's Threefold Resolve

Bhagavati Adishakti herself resolved that she would take birth as a daughter in Daksha's house. Behind this lay three profound purposes. First, to bring Shiva into householder life, so that he might establish for the world an ideal — that even the supreme ascetic accepts love and family, that vairagya does not mean turning away from affection, but rather non-attachment even within affection. Second, to teach Prajapatis like Daksha, so fond of ritual and so proud, that devotion and love stand higher even than yajna and rule — that inner surrender is greater than outward pomp. Third — and this was the most profound purpose of all — to pass herself once through the fire of separation and sacrifice, and then to reappear in the form of Parvati, thereby proving that true devotion is never destroyed, only changes its form, and that even death cannot separate love.

This threefold resolve was not merely the beginning of a story — it was the prologue to an eternal message for creation, one that would be remembered through the ages as a symbol of woman's chastity (satitva), surrender, and indomitable courage.

An Auspicious Sign in Daksha's Palace

A short while later, a strange occurrence took place in Daksha's palace. Asikni had a dream — in the dream she saw an otherworldly light entering her womb, and at that very instant the whole palace was filled with a divine fragrance. Waking, she related this dream to Daksha. Daksha took it as an auspicious omen, had yajnas performed, gave gifts to the Brahmins — but he did not know that this was no ordinary announcement of pregnancy, but the forewarning of the very descent of Adishakti.

The Silent Acknowledgment of the Saptarishis

In this same period, the Saptarishis too received a sign of this event through their journey across the sky. Marichi, Atri, Angira, Pulastya, Pulaha, Kratu, and Vasishtha — these seven great sages saw with their divine sight that no ordinary being was entering Asikni's womb, but the very concentrated form of Prakriti herself. Sage Vasishtha said to his disciples, "This pregnancy is not merely the glory of Daksha's lineage; it will become the very axis of the future of all three worlds. The daughter born of it will, for ages, be remembered by name as the symbol of renunciation, surrender, and satitva." The disciples asked in wonder, "Gurudev, will this daughter live a happy life?" Sage Vasishtha remained silent for a moment, then spoke in a grave voice — "The definitions of joy and sorrow differ for ordinary men, and differ for Adishakti. She will teach the world even through her own separation."

A Parallel Waiting in the Himalayas

At the very time this auspicious sign was appearing in Daksha's palace, in the foothills of the Himalayas, near Mount Mainak, Himalayaraj himself and his wife Mena were also caught in an unknown waiting. They did not yet know that, in time, this same Shakti would descend once more into their own house — in the form of Parvati. This is that subtle thread of the story which is still in seed-form, but which will, in the volumes ahead, appear as a vast tree. It is the law of creation that in every beginning its future lies hidden somewhere — one need only the vision to recognize it.

Stir in the Assembly of the Gods

This news reached the heavenly realm as well. Indra asked Brihaspati, "Gurudev, what sign is this, that Adishakti herself is about to be born in Daksha's house?" Brihaspati answered, "O Lord of the Gods, whenever the balance between pride and devotion is disturbed in creation, Adishakti herself descends in some form or another to restore it. Daksha's pride is still in seed-form, but with time it will grow into a tree and cast creation into peril. This is why Mother herself is taking birth in his house — to quell that pride from within." Hearing this, all the gods were astonished, and each began, in his own way, to prepare to welcome this divine descent.

The Prologue of a Future

In this chapter we have seen how, between the pride of one Prajapati and the resolve of one Adishakti, the seed of a story is sown that will, in time, be counted among the most poignant and most divine chapters of creation. Daksha does not yet know that his own most radiant child will shatter his pride — and that, through her own sacrifice, she will establish a tradition that will, for ages, make the word "Sati" synonymous with purity, surrender, and indomitable courage. Narada's prophecy has now gathered momentum, and that light has already entered Asikni's womb — a light that will soon illumine all three worlds.

Chapter-Closing Verse

न तस्य कार्यं करणं च विद्यते न तत्समश्चाभ्यधिकश्च दृश्यते।

परास्य शक्तिर्विविधैव श्रूयते स्वाभाविकी ज्ञानबलक्रिया च॥

Meaning - That Supreme Lord has no special task to perform, nor any servant for it — none is his equal, none surpasses him. It is his supreme power (para shakti) alone that is heard to manifest in manifold forms — as knowledge, as strength, and as action. This very Shakti is soon to manifest in the forms of Sati and Parvati.

The Beginning of a Silent Waiting

Thus, neither Daksha, nor Asikni, nor most beings of creation itself had full knowledge of what was about to happen in the days to come. Only a few sages endowed with divine sight, a few of the higher gods, and Lord Shiva himself — who already knew everything within his meditation — were witnesses to this unfolding play. Upon Kailash, a subtle smile floated across Shiva's lips, as though he knew that soon his solitary tapasya would move toward a new chapter. This smile was neither of joy nor of sorrow — it was of that supreme balance which is the essential nature of the principle of Shiva.



Conclusion — The Meeting of Two Natures

Thus, in the primeval age of creation, two dispositions came to stand face to face — on one side, Daksha's rule-bound, ritual-centered, society-centered world; on the other, Shiva's formless, rule-free, inward-turned world of tapasya. Adishakti herself took upon herself the responsibility of becoming the bridge between these two. This chapter is the first brick in the building of that divine bridge — a foundation upon which, in the chapters ahead, the entire saga of Sati's birth, childhood, tapasya, marriage, and finally her great sacrifice will be woven.

Let the reader not view this chapter merely as a mythological prologue, but seek in it a reflection of one's own life — for within every human being there sits, somewhere, a Daksha, entangled in rules, and somewhere too a Shiva, absorbed in silent sadhana (spiritual practice). Striving for balance between these two is the first message of this tale.

Summary

This chapter gives a detailed account of Daksha Prajapati's lineage, his nature, his pride, his limited understanding of Shiva, and the prophecy of the sage Narada. It also shows how Adishakti herself made a threefold resolve to be born as Sati — to bring Shiva into householder life, to teach Daksha's pride a lesson, and to prove the immortality of devotion. At the end of the chapter comes the sign of that divine light entering Asikni's womb, which will manifest in the chapters to come as the birth of Sati.

Thus concludes the first chapter, named "Birth of Sati," in the first section of the sacred tale of Mahasati Gauri.

Thus, in the first section "Birth of Sati" of the sacred tale of Shri Mahasati Gauri, the first chapter, named "Daksha Prajapati and His Lineage," comes to completion.

A Note from the Servant (Nimitta)

While writing this chapter, I was reminded of a truth of my own life, one I have been living for years — that in every family, in every lineage, an invisible conflict runs between rule and love. I too have, at times, been entangled like Daksha in the very proprieties I built for myself, and at other times sought happiness, like Shiva, in formless devotion. But Mother Ambe has taught me that true balance lies between the two — to observe rule while still keeping alight in the heart that flame of devotion which is beholden to no ritual. From the day that light enters Asikni's womb, this tale becomes, for me too, a sadhana — with every chapter I write, I feel the nearness of Mother. Jai Maa Ambe. Jai Bhagavati Gauri.

Shri Adishakti Mahakosh

Khand 1 - Birth of Sati